

A rotten deal

The **impending threat** of further tariff reductions on Washington apples **has** sent shock waves through the country's apple-growing regions. With import duties already **slashed** from 70 per cent to 50 per cent in 2023, **orchardists** fear another cut would **flood** the market with cheap, high-quality American apples, **devastating** domestic growers. The numbers tell a **sobering** story. When **tariffs** were **hiked** in 2018, US apple imports **plummeted** from 1.28 lakh metric tonnes to just 4,486 metric tonnes by 2022-23. But after the duty was reduced, imports **surged** nearly 20 times. Any further relaxation would make Washington apples as affordable — or even cheaper — than premium domestic varieties, threatening the **livelihoods** of around seven lakh farming families.

India's agricultural tariffs are a key **sticking point** in US trade **negotiations**. While it **imposes** high duties — 45 per cent on soya beans, 50 per cent on maize, 5 per cent on cotton and a steep 150 per cent on processed food — the US wants lower barriers for its farm exports. However, trade cannot be a one-way street. If India must make **concessions**, it should secure **reciprocal** market access for its produce and processed foods.



Apple growers already face **stiff** competition from cheap Iranian imports and struggle with high production costs due to the **rugged** Himalayan **terrain** which makes **mechanisation** impossible. **In contrast**, American apples benefit from highly mechanised farming and **large-scale subsidies**. This **imbalance** makes India's apple industry extremely **vulnerable** to unregulated imports. **Any tariff cut** without protective measures **would cripple** an industry already **on the edge**. If 'Vocal for Local' is to be more than a slogan, India must **resist** pressure to lower import duties blindly. It should negotiate smartly — protecting vulnerable sectors while expanding export opportunities. **[Practice Exercise]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.
- **In contrast** (phrase) – to show that you are mentioning a very different situation from the one इसके विपरीत

Vocabulary

1. **Rotten** (adjective) – Awful, terrible, nasty, foul, unpleasant बहुत बुरा
2. **Impending** (adjective) – Approaching, Looming, Forthcoming, Imminent, Upcoming सन्निकट
3. **Slash** (verb) – Cut, Reduce, Lower, Decrease, Drop काटना
4. **Orchardist** (noun) – Fruit grower, Apple farmer, Horticulturist, Cultivator, Grower बागवान
5. **Flood** (verb) – Overwhelm, Inundate, Swamp, Deluge, Engulf भर देना
6. **Devastating** (adjective) – Destructive, Catastrophic, Ruinous, Harmful, Damaging विनाशकारी
7. **Sobering** (adjective) – Serious, Alarming, Eye-opening, Thought-provoking, Harsh गंभीर
8. **Tariff** (noun) – Duty, Tax, Levy, Charge, Impost शुल्क
9. **Hike** (verb) – Increase, Raise, Boost, Escalate, Augment बढ़ाना
10. **Plummet** (verb) – Drop, Fall, Decline, Crash, Plunge गिरना
11. **Surge** (verb) – Rise, Increase, Soar, Escalate, Jump तेजी से बढ़ना
12. **Livelihood** (noun) – Income, Earnings, Subsistence, Occupation, Living रोजी-रोटी
13. **Sticking point** (phrase) – Obstacle, Hurdle, Impasse, Issue, Problem अड़चन
14. **Negotiation** (noun) – Discussion, Bargaining, Dialogue, Talks, Mediation बातचीत
15. **Impose** (verb) – Enforce, Levy, Apply, Introduce, Inflict थोपना
16. **Concession** (noun) – Compromise, Allowance, Adjustment, Trade-off, Grant रियायत
17. **Reciprocal** (adjective) – Mutual, Bilateral, Corresponding, Equivalent, Exchange पारस्परिक
18. **Stiff** (adjective) – Tough, Hard, Rigid, Severe, Strong कठोर
19. **Rugged** (adjective) – Rough, Uneven, Rocky, Harsh, Tough बीहड़
20. **Terrain** (noun) – Landscape, Topography, Ground, Territory, Land इलाका
21. **Mechanisation** (noun) – Automation, Industrialization, Modernization, Mechanization, Robotization यंत्रीकरण
22. **Large-scale** (adjective) – Extensive, Widespread, Massive, Broad, Comprehensive बड़े पैमाने पर

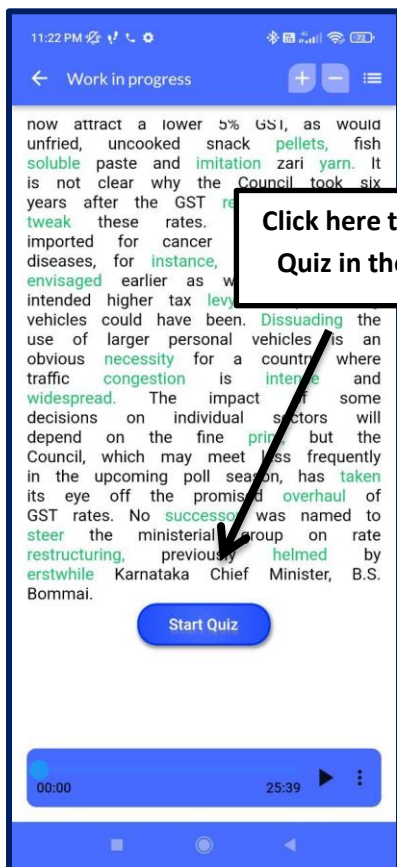
23. **Subsidies** (noun) – Grants, Aid, Support, Funding, Allowance सब्सिडी
24. **Imbalance** (noun) – Disparity, Inequality, Disproportion, Asymmetry, Instability असंतुलन
25. **Vulnerable** (adjective) – Exposed, Susceptible, Defenseless, Weak, At risk कमजोर
26. **Cripple** (verb) – Weaken, Disable, Paralyze, Debilitate, Hinder कमजोर करना
27. **On the edge** (phrase) – At risk, In danger, Under pressure, Precarious, Vulnerable खतरे में
28. **Resist** (verb) – Oppose, Withstand, Defy, Combat, Counter विरोध करना
29. **Negotiate** (verb) – Bargain, Discuss, Mediate, Conclude, Arrange बातचीत करना

@mocks_wallah

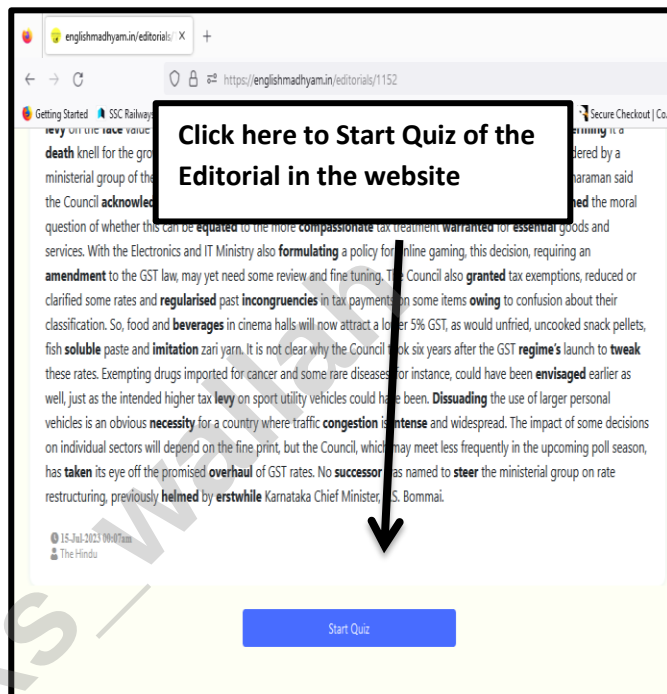
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Tariff Reduction Threat:** The potential for further cuts in import duties on Washington apples has alarmed India's apple-growing regions.
2. **Previous Duty Cuts:** Import duties on US apples were reduced from 70% to 50% in 2023, leading to a surge in imports.
3. **Impact of Tariff Changes:** When tariffs were raised in 2018, US apple imports dropped sharply, but the 2023 reduction caused imports to increase nearly 20 times.
4. **Market Flooding Risk:** Further tariff cuts could make Washington apples as affordable or cheaper than premium Indian varieties, threatening domestic growers.
5. **Livelihoods at Stake:** Around seven lakh farming families depend on apple cultivation, and their livelihoods are at risk from unregulated imports.
6. **US Trade Demands:** The US is pushing for lower agricultural tariffs in India, which currently imposes high duties on products like soya beans, maize, cotton, and processed foods.
7. **Reciprocal Trade Needed:** India should demand reciprocal market access for its agricultural and processed food exports if it agrees to lower tariffs.
8. **Competition from Iran:** Indian apple growers already face stiff competition from cheaper Iranian imports.
9. **High Production Costs:** Indian apple farming is costly due to the rugged Himalayan terrain, which limits mechanization.
10. **US Advantage:** American apple growers benefit from highly mechanized farming and large-scale subsidies, giving them a competitive edge.
11. **Vulnerable Industry:** India's apple industry is highly vulnerable to unregulated imports due to these imbalances.
12. **Need for Protection:** Tariff cuts without protective measures could devastate the already struggling domestic apple industry.
13. **Vocal for Local:** The government must ensure that the "Vocal for Local" initiative translates into real protection for domestic industries.
14. **Smart Negotiations:** India should negotiate trade deals strategically, safeguarding vulnerable sectors while expanding export opportunities.
15. **Balanced Trade Policy:** A balanced approach is needed to protect domestic growers while fostering fair and reciprocal trade relations.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



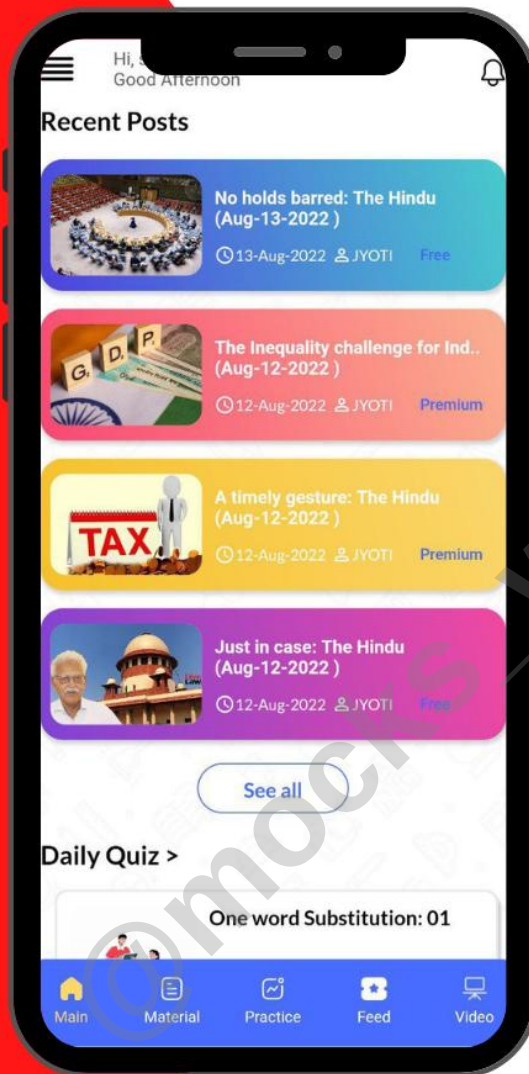
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